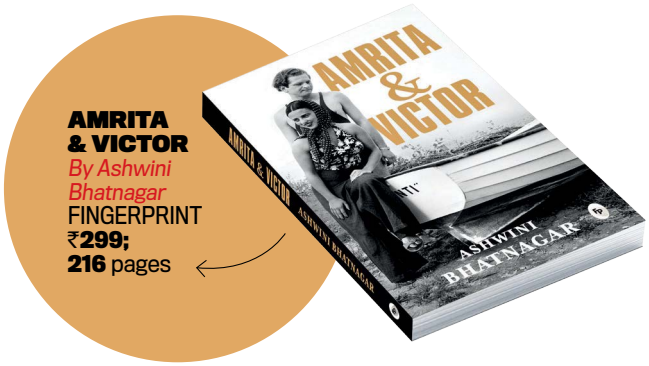


AMRITA & VICTOR
By Ashwini Bhatnagar
FINGERPRINT
₹299;
216 pages

BOOKS

WOMAN IN LOVE

IN THIS IMAGINATIVE ACCOUNT OF **AMRITA SHER-GIL**'S LIFE AND LOVES, THE CULT OF THE INDIAN PAINTER LIVES ON

There are artists whose private lives loom larger than their art, in the public imagination, to their disadvantage. Amrita Sher-Gil is one such. Her mother thought she was grossly promiscuous. Others, including later observers, prefer to see her as exhilaratingly liberated, though some struggle coming to terms with how bold she was, even for our times, never mind for India in the 1930s. Many male authors unwittingly display a sort of saviour syndrome: if only (they seem to imply) I had been around at the time, instead of that odd fellow Victor (her cousin on her mother's side, whom she married), things would have turned out better. For some men, the thought of a beautiful woman who slept around and died at 28 is just too much to bear.

The worst case is Charles Fabri, who wrote a novel, *Indian Flamingo* (1947), in which a charming and erudite museum curator (closely modelled on himself) meets the captivating and talented artist Padma (based on Amrita) and she is as besotted with him as he is with her! Deterred by family disapproval, she briefly runs away from the affair, but the hero literally carries her back in his arms, kissing her as he goes. All one can say about that plot line is: Hurrah for museum curators!

Ashwini Bhatnagar has not written a novel—at least this book is not declared as such—but he has fictionalised his telling of the story. *Amrita & Victor* is full of long and detailed conversations, between the two main protagonists and their friends and relatives, some parts of which are based on surviving letters, but much of which is simply imagined. It reads like the script of a costume drama. You know that these actual historical figures did not, in fact, utter these particular words; but they might have said things like this if they were, in life, anything like how this author imagines them to be. Which raises the question: how does he know?

The book is full of detailed conversations between the two protagonists. Some parts of that are based on surviving letters, but much of it is simply imagined

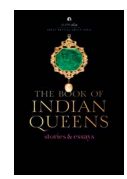
There is a great deal more detail here about Amrita's various affairs, and about what she was thinking and feeling from day to day in her short life, than other more scrupulous biographers have felt able to divulge. Where Bhatnagar has found this additional material, he doesn't say. As he is a seasoned and responsible journalist, one wants to give him credit for due diligence with respect to his sources. But there are many historical and stylistic slips that limit credibility. This is less a work of biography than one person's fanciful retelling of a familiar tale. We might even see it as yet another of Amrita's triumphs, emanating from the force of her personality. Sadly, not from her art. ■

Giles Tillotson

BOOKS

ROYAL REPAST

The Book of Indian Queens is a sumptuous selection of accounts of the women who have ruled India



THE BOOK OF INDIAN QUEENS
Stories & Essays
ALEPH BOOK COMPANY
₹399;
120 pages

Ruskin Bond's *rani* in his short story 'The Room of Many Colours' is a mysterious figure, sometimes preening, sometimes petulant. As with any Ruskin Bond story, the prose is simple and charming. Bond's queen is nameless, unlike the other queens this story shares space with. She is also fictitious. Rani is one of 12 royals depicted in the slim anthology, *The Book of Indian Queens*. It's a slender reminder that while Indian society and politics have been male-dominated, every now and then a powerful female figure comes along. As the introduction tells us, the word 'queen' is used loosely, and includes "all women who were rulers of royal birth—empresses, queens, regents, princesses, begums and so on".

Historian Abraham Eraly's short excerpt from *The First Spring: Life in the Golden Age of India* (2011) places these extraordinary women in their context. Even though "Indian law books and religious texts generally deny women any role in politics", he writes, "as in much else in classical India, practice diverged greatly from prescription."

The pieces are agnostic in style and flavour, encompassing a mix of personal memoir (Maharani Gayatri Devi), Mughal history (Ruby Lal on Nur Jahan) and historical fiction (Mahasweta Devi on Rani Lakshmibai). Royals from the north dominate, including from Punjab, Awadh and Kashmir. But queens from elsewhere also come alive in Manu S. Pillai's piece on Travancore's regents and Binodini's take on the Manipuri princess Sanatombi.

As these excerpts illustrate, women rulers are equal to their male counterparts at ruling, charming, leading armies and, of course, engaging in politicking and courtly intrigue.

The anthology includes some of the biggest names in both history and fiction working in India today, and gestures towards some of the larger storylines and historical arcs of the characters featured. *The Book of Indian Queens* succeeds as a historical appetiser, for anyone keen on a quick introduction to the subcontinent's women royals. ■

Bhavya Dore